

Open Source as Institutional Infrastructure

Lessons from the UC OSPO Network

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The invisible layer



Research data workflows run on open source:

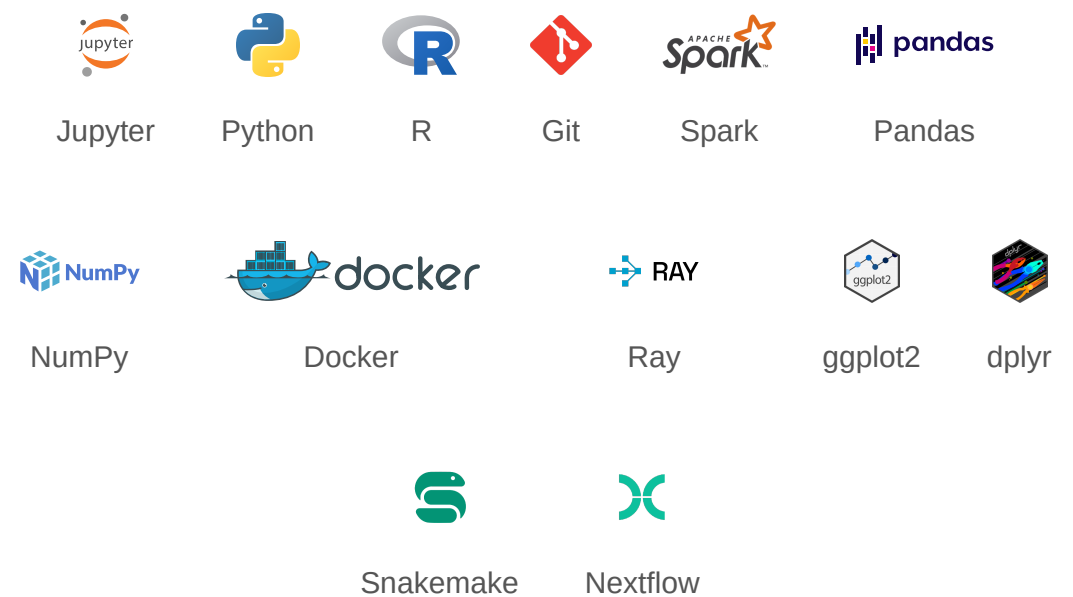
- Data collection, cleaning, analysis, visualization
- Reproducibility tooling: containers, workflows, version control
- Repositories and scholarly infrastructure

92% of researchers use software; **67%** say their research would be impossible without it.

The people keeping it running are increasingly called **Research Software Engineers (RSEs)**, a growing professional community with no standard institutional home.

If every organization had to replace open source with proprietary equivalents, the cost would exceed **\$8.8 trillion**.

Hettrick et al. (SSI, 2014/2022) · Hoffmann, Nagle & Zhou (2024)
doi:10.2139/ssrn.4693148



We've been here before

People in this room helped build the open data movement:

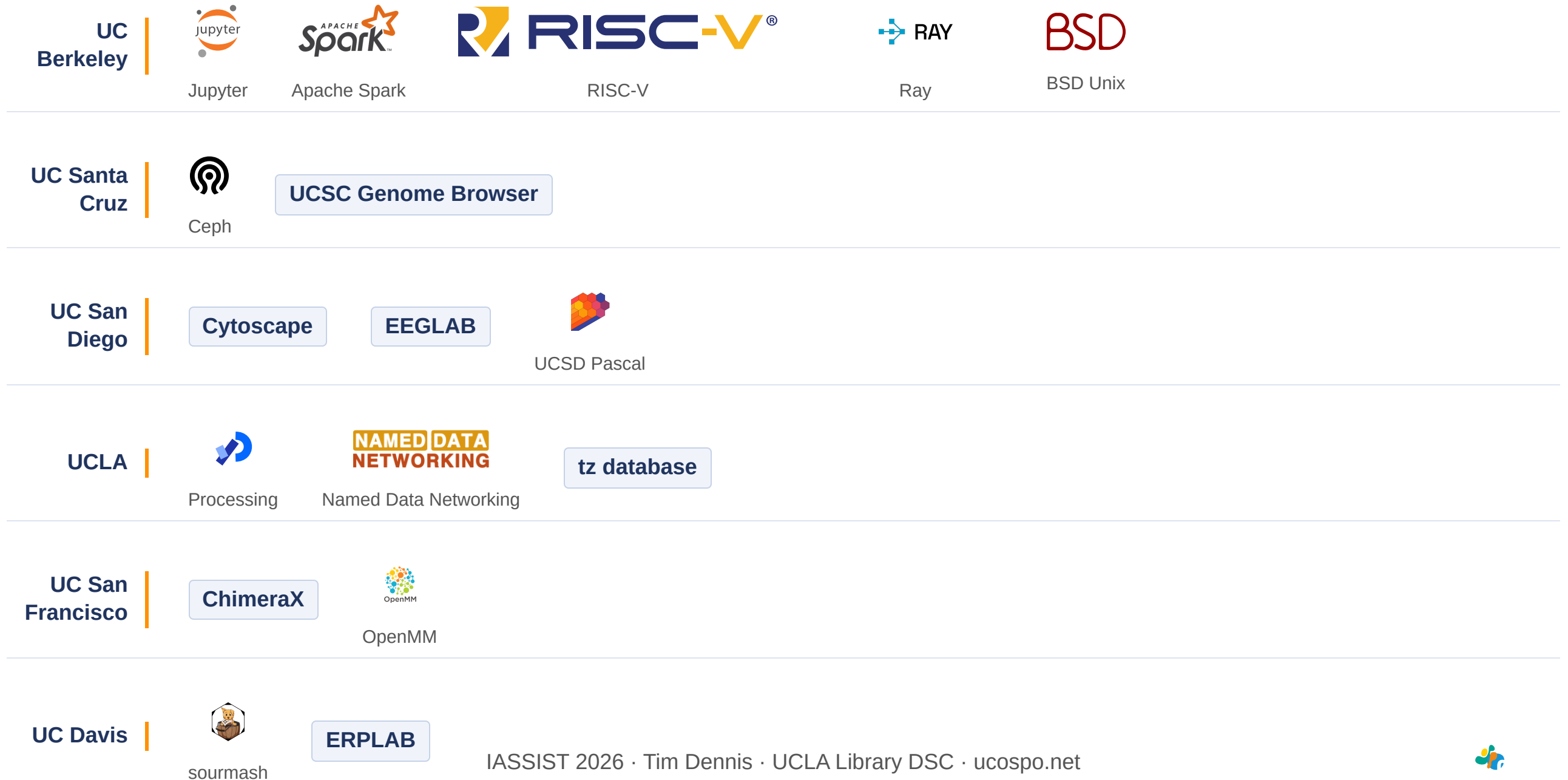
- FAIR principles: from aspiration to institutional expectation
- Data management plans embedded in grant workflows
- Curation, provenance, and stewardship as professional services
- Open science infrastructure: repositories, PIDs, metadata standards
- **FAIR4RS**: FAIR principles now extended to research software

Software is the next frontier, and UC has been showing the way for 50 years: BSD Unix, Ceph, Apache Spark, RISC-V, Ray. The pipeline from university research to global infrastructure is not rare or accidental.

“The research done in academia was the seed. Foundations provided the soil. But the community was the sun.”



The UC research-to-infrastructure pipeline



Summer 2000. UC Santa Cruz.

PhD student Jim Kent assembled the human genome on 50 borrowed PCs, icing his wrists to keep coding.

He finished **three days** before a corporate competitor's supercomputer.

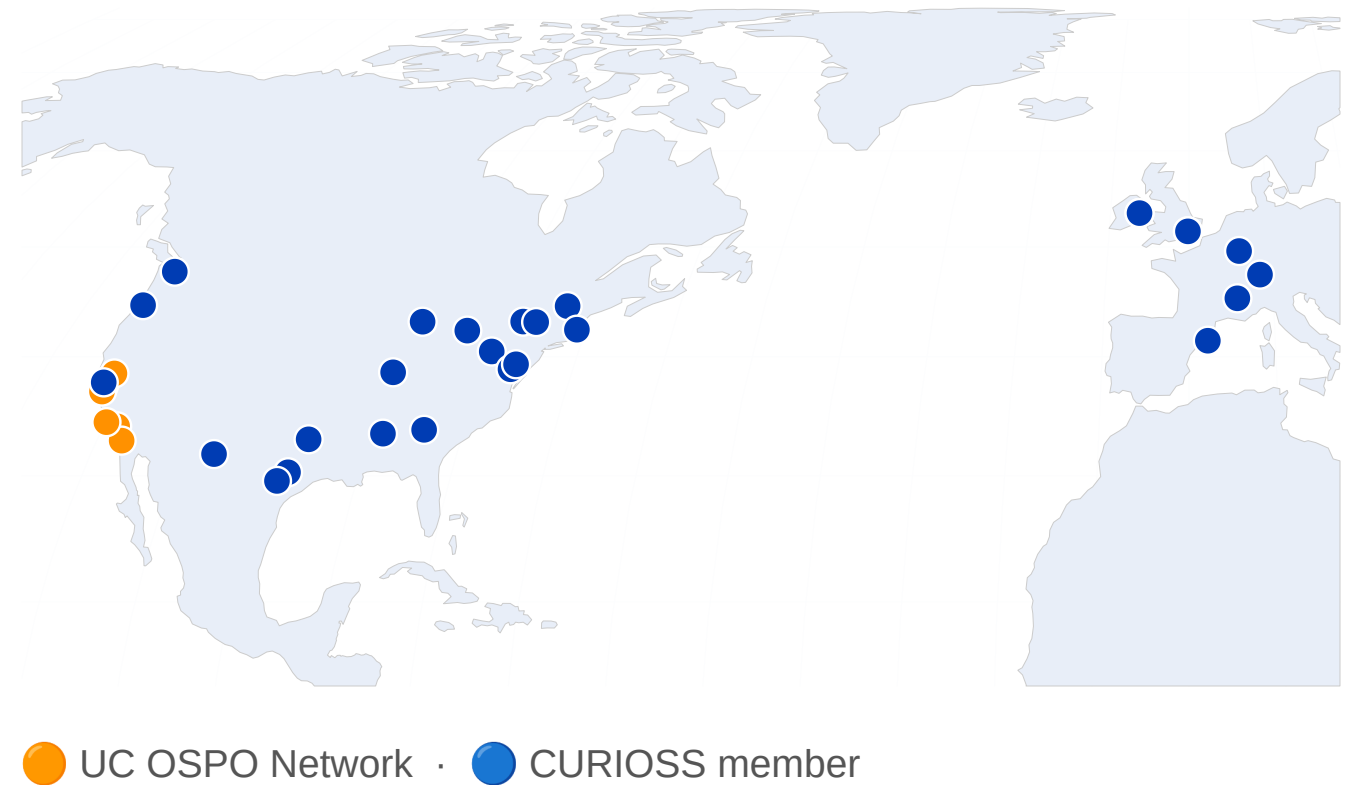
The genome stayed in the public domain.

Kent, J.W. (2002). BLAT - The BLAST-Like Alignment Tool. *Genome Research* 12, 656–664. · genome.ucsc.edu

What is an academic OSPO?

An **Open Source Program Office** supports, governs, and promotes open source within an institution.

- Originated in industry: ~77% of large tech companies have one
- First academic OSPO: Johns Hopkins, 2019
- **34 academic OSPOs** in CURIOS member worldwide and growing
- Core functions: policy, licensing guidance, best practices, education, community



The UC OSPO Network



Three thematic areas



Discovery

Mapping who does what
across the UC system:
repos, contributors, tools,
and practices



Sustainability

Keeping projects and
communities healthy
through licensing, project
health, and community
support



Education

Coordinated training and
learning pathways across
campuses



Discovery: knowing what's there

The 4 Ps framework, applied at system scale:

- **People:** who contributes to OS software at UC?
- **Product:** what has been built?
- **Practice:** how do faculty and staff engage?
- **Perception:** what are contributors' experiences?

Tools: GitHub pipeline (200,000+ repos scanned; ~52,000 institutionally affiliated across 10 campuses), network-wide survey (294 respondents), UC Open Repository Browser (UC ORB)

Gomez et al. (2025) [arxiv:2506.18359](https://arxiv.org/abs/2506.18359) · Scarlett et al. (2025) [doi:10.31235/osf.io/p8bx6_v1](https://doi.org/10.31235/osf.io/p8bx6_v1)



Sustainability: keeping it running

58% of UC open source contributors are also maintainers. Not users: stewards.

What they asked for most: sustainability grants, computing infrastructure, learning communities.

#1 challenge: finding time to write documentation.

Nationally: **60%** of maintainers are unpaid; **43%** report burnout.

Network services:

- Cross-campus licensing working group (UCOP + tech transfer + IT)
- Project health assessment (OSSPREY)
- Containerization support · Community management

58%

of UC OSS contributors
are also **maintainers**
not just users, stewards

60%

unpaid nationally

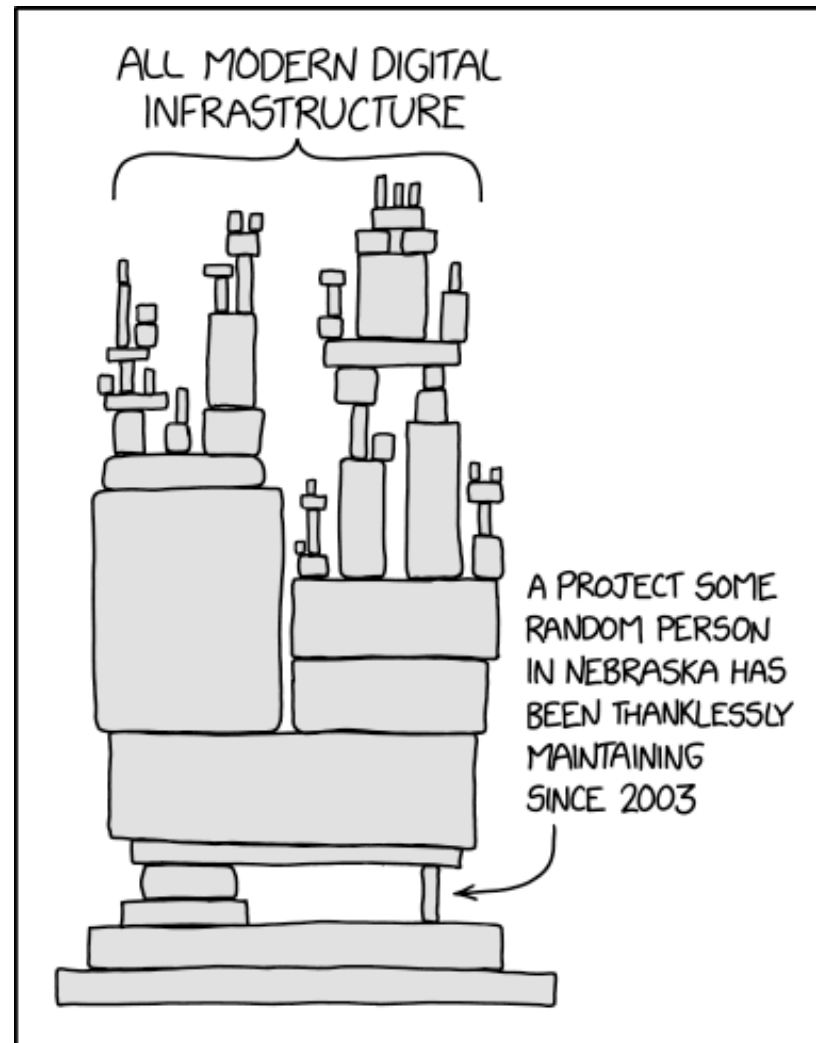
43%

report burnout

Tidelift (2024) State of the Open Source Maintainer Report



The dependency problem



XKCD #2347 'Dependency': a towering stack of blocks labeled 'All modern digital infrastructure' balances on a single tiny block labeled 'A project some random person in Nebraska has been thanklessly maintaining since 2003'. By Randall Munroe.

xkcd #2347 (CC BY-NC 2.5) · UC survey: 58% of contributors are maintainers · Tidelift (2024): 60% unpaid, 43% burnt out



AI and open source: a new pressure

AI code generation is changing what it means to maintain a project.

- **Slop PRs:** AI-generated contributions that look complete but are off-spec, shallow, or carry subtle bugs
- Review burden grows while maintainer capacity stays flat
- The OSS projects that trained the models are now flooded by their output
- Security risk: AI-generated code in dependencies with undetected vulnerabilities

OSPOs are developing responses: contribution disclosure policies, AI-aware code review norms, project-level guidance.

Baltes, Cheong & Treude (2026) arxiv:2603.27249 · GitClear (2024) “Coding on Copilot”

The structural shift

70% of new AI PhDs go straight to industry

(a decade ago: 50/50)

90% of notable AI models come from a handful of companies

Academia is being sidelined from the systems it helped create.

Ruff (2026) UC Open Summit ·
youtu.be/eBriL3CDNeo



Education: training as infrastructure

Gap analysis → curriculum inventory → learning pathways

- Inventoried existing materials: Carpentries, CodeRefinery, The Turing Way, UC-specific content
- Organized by topic (licensing, sustainability, community) and by role (contributor, maintainer, manager)
- Published at ucospo.net/education
- Coordinated with data literacy programs and Carpentries infrastructure



Distributed expertise, system-wide capacity

Each campus brings what others don't. The network routes it to where it's needed.

Each campus contributes

- Unique domain expertise and staff knowledge
- Local relationships with researchers and faculty
- Pilots that can only run with campus context
- Specialized capacity others can learn from

The network multiplies it

- Expertise flows across all six campuses
- Shared staffing no single campus could fund
- Smaller campuses build capacity they couldn't alone
- A success at one becomes a template for five

Governed by an OSPO Leadership Group and thematic working groups, one per campus, coordinated at system level.





Lessons from two years

What the network model enables that single campuses cannot:

1. **Shared staffing:** community manager, licensing specialist, technical roles
2. **Policy leverage:** the network has standing with UCOP; individual campuses do not
3. **Data at scale:** the GitHub and survey analyses require system-wide scope to mean anything
4. **Equity:** smaller campuses get services they could not build alone
5. **A replicable model:** \$1.85M produced something other state systems can follow



Where this meets your work

For data professionals, the OSPO sits at the intersection of:

- Research software engineering ↔ data management
- Licensing compliance ↔ open data policy
- Reproducibility tooling ↔ FAIR / FAIR4RS
- Training infrastructure ↔ data literacy programs
- RSE community ↔ library research support

For your institution:

- Where does open source software governance currently live?
- What would it take to treat it as infrastructure rather than a side project?



You're already doing this work



What you can do right now

If you advise on data-intensive research, you are probably already helping with code.

The network has already built the resources:

- [README.md](#) - template + guide (Laura Langdon, UC OSPO)
- [LICENSE](#) - guide includes UC-approved options
- [CONTRIBUTING.md](#) - template + guide
- [CODE_OF_CONDUCT.md](#) - Contributor Covenant + guidance
- [CITATION.cff](#) + Zenodo release → citable, versioned DOI

Going further:

- [Growing a Community Around a Project](#) - UC OSPO
- [Sharing Research Software: Reproducible, Citable, and Discoverable](#) - Carpentries Incubator lesson (covers [pixi](#), [CITATION.cff](#), Zenodo, discoverability)



Learn more / connect

UC OSPO Network: ucospo.net

- Education site: ucospo.net/education
- Mailing list, Slack, events calendar

Global network: curiOSS.org, 34 academic OSPOs worldwide and growing

Tim Dennis Data Science Center, UCLA Library dennis.tim@gmail.com

 One-page reference handout (project origins, network stats, resources): iassist-2026-handout.html

